Bouquet of Red Flags – A Collection

By Taylor Mali

Magnifies an Object Ten Times

"Magnifies an Object Ten Times" is what it clearly said
on the handle of the magnifying glass
my father received on his fifth birthday.
He took it as a warning; the birthday gift
would only work its magic ten times
and no more, becoming, after that,
just a small round window with no miracle,
toy giant's monocle, a circle of simple glass.

And so he went about his days with curious thrift,
weighing how much he needed to see any part
of the world up close, observing as best he could
with his own eyes first, thinking, *Do I need to see*
that dead bug big? That dandelion, that blade
of grass, that wriggling moth in the spider's web?
I can imagine most of nature's gifts and crimes.
Best not to waste one of my ten precious times.

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He lost count of how many miracles he had left,
and for weeks after half expected the magic of the glass
to simply stop. And I have asked him to tell me
of the thrilling moment he realized, or was told,
"ten times" in this context simply meant *tenfold*
and not ten instances, but he cannot remember.
Likewise the joy that must have come with such
a limitless epiphany. But what he does recall
and says most he misses still is the way the magic
made him see the world the rest of the time,
not through the glass, but all the time
he thought that magic would not last.

INTRODUCTION

Our families teach us, intentionally or not, how we see the world . . . a world where contradictions can and do live side by side. The words and memories echo even more loudly upon the death of a parent – or in Taylor Mali's case both parents -- sometimes playing an endless loop of emotion that we can't easily quiet.

You see, our relationships are preserved, not just in objects or people, but in the way they are remembered.

Poems from Bouquet of Red Flags by Taylor Mali

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My Deepest Condiments

I send you my deepest condiments
was in no way what my old friend
meant to say or write or send
the night she penned a note to me
one week after my father died.

Not ***condolences***, or ***sentiments***,
she sent me her deepest condiments
instead, as if the dead have need
of relish, mustard, and ketchup
on the other side.

O, the word made me laugh
so hard out loud it hurt!
So wonderfully absurd,
and such a sweet relief
at a time when it seemed

only grief was allowed in
after my father's death,
sweet and simple laughter,
which is nothing more than breath

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from so far deep inside

it often brings up with it tears.
And so I laughed and laughed
until my sides were sore.
And later still, I even cried
a little more.

TRANSITION

Memories of childhood come flashing back . . .

Shut up and You Know I Love You

***** *Author's note about this poem*

They're from kitchen cabinets, behind the poison
and insecticides.
They're from locked bedroom doors.
They're from dolls and Hunger Games,
rock, paper, scissors,
three lives, and you're dead.
You're out.
You are not my friend.
No. Not it.
That seat is taken.

They're from shut up and you know I love you.

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They're from get out of my room.

They're from stupid.

They're from fat, ugly, and I hate you.

Shut up and you know I love you.

They're from you're not a part of the real family.

You're adopted.

Why do you keep hitting yourself?

Why do you keep hitting yourself?

Look what you made me do.

Mom and Dad said you were a mistake.

They're from please don't tell. This can be our secret.

Two hours of piano every night before dinner.

Do you want the stick? Do I need to get the belt?

Don't make me tell you again.

You brought this on yourself.

They're from tears of laughter, and tears,

and I never wanted any of this to happen.

I am so sorry. I promise I'll never do it again.

They're from you know I love you.

This is going to hurt me more than it hurts you.

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TRANSITION

Within weeks of his father's death, Taylor Mali's mother also passed away. Her name was Jane and "The Troubled Muddle of the Midfield" describes Mali's reflections of the day she died . . . "not knowing how to help or where to run."

The Troubled Muddle of the Midfield

The afternoon of the evening my mother was to die

I lingered on the sidelines of a soccer game too long

just to watch the Burden twins do what they do best.

Six minutes between the two, offensive sister

and her defensive twin separated by only six minutes,

except for the entire troubled muddle of the midfield,

that huddled gaggle of other girls who ran crookedly

between the two sisters like a sad flock on stilts.

Jane was the goalie, and she repelled every shot

she did not devour, while Jane -- The Other Jane,

that was her name,

or rather what we called the younger

just to keep them straight

(instead of questioning the inane logic of their names,

How insane must you be to name both your daughters

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Jane?) --
she reigned over the field at center forward,
left foot like a laser beam.

The afternoon of the evening my mother was to die
I prepared two weeks of lesson plans
for the teachers who would take my place
while I was away.

And I made a wish that the Girls' Varsity Soccer Team
would one day have a more capable midfield
instead of the cacophony of awkwardness,
the never knowing where to go
to be of any use to anyone,
which explains the long balls arcing downfield
from the massive volley of Jane
to the sparkling feet of The Other Jane,
juking her way through the stupefied topiary of opposing
players.

I suspect there are several ways a man can deal with grief,
but the afternoon of the evening my mother was to die
I watched the Burden twins beat their rivals seven-zero,
watched them for longer than I should have,

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knowing I had a four-hour drive to the bedside
of still another Jane
and the near certain promise of mourning.

My mother died without me.
And it has now been years since
the missing of that moment,
the lingering in this riddled life she suffered
waiting for me to tell her
what I only hope she knew already.

Still now sometimes when I think of her,
I see Jane and The Other Jane
and the wonder of the way they moved,
the one never letting anything in,
the way the other made motionless the world.
And also the confusion of everything in between,
midfield of the twin Burdens,
the not knowing how to help or where to run.

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* *Kids say the darnedest things, and every line in this poem is based off one written for me by students at the International School of Beijing in the spring of 2014. I asked them all to make lists of things: favorite hiding places, things they hear from their family a lot, games they played as children, and popular punishments in their family. – Based on the form of the poem 'Origins' by Jeffrey McDaniel (https://upittpress.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/9780822959953exr.pdf)*

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